NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥J

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♣2

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 5♦
Declarer: South
Lead: ♠Q

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♣K

Board: 5
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6♣
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥10

Board: 6
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 2♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠Q

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ Q J 10 5 ♥ K 5 4 ♦ A K 6 ♣ A 5 2	
♠ A 6 ♥ 6 3 ♦ Q 10 9 8 4 ♣ Q J 10 6	N W E S	♠ K 9 8 2 ♥ J 10 9 8 ♦ J 2 ♣ 9 7 3
	♠ 7 4 3 ♥ A Q 7 2 ♦ 7 5 3 ♣ K 8 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♣
Pass	2♠	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥J

In response to partner's Stayman bid you show your 4-card ♠ suit. Partner now bids 2NT.

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You may disagree with the Stayman bid on 3-4-3-3 distribution. In any case, 2NT is invitational, so with 17 points you say 3NT.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥J.

Winner List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 3/4 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 7/8

East's ♥J lead probably means ♥s won't be 3-3, so you will need to get 2 ♠ tricks.

Suppose you win the first trick and plunk down the ♠Q. If West wins with a doubleton ♠ honor you will only be able to win 1 ♠ since East will sit there with ♠ A 9 or ♠ K 9 behind your ♠ J 10.

Instead, win the first trick in dummy and play a small ♠ toward the ♠ Q J 10. West will play low and East must take his ♠ honor. But you can win his return, enter dummy and play another ♠ toward your hand. If you are lucky, West will be forced to play an honor and you can toss your ♠5.

This plan, leading toward your ♠ holding twice, will succeed the majority of the time.

It only fails if East holds 4 or more ♠s headed by A K.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ K Q 10 3 ♥ Q 10 6 3 ♦ K 7 5 2 ♣ 8	
♠ 8 6 5 ♥ K 7 2 ♦ A Q 9 ♣ 10 6 4 3		♠ A 7 4 ♥ A 9 4 ♦ 8 6 3 ♣ A K Q 9
	♠ J 9 2 ♥ J 8 5 ♦ J 10 4 ♣ J 7 5 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2NT	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♣2

A square hand, no 4-card Major, and 9 points. This is the very hand that the book said to bid 2NT with. And when you do, partner says 3NT which you pass.

The contract would be 3NT played by West.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♣2. You must be living right, South gives you a trick with the opening lead.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 4 :: Total = 8

You got a good break on the opening lead, now you need only one more winner. There is **NO CHANCE** of creating another winner in ♠s, ♥s or ♣s, so your second good break is that you know it will have to be ♦s.

You **COULD** lead toward dummy's ♦Q, finessing South for the ♦K. That would be a perfectly good 50% chance. But there is an even better play if you look carefully.

Play a ♦ from your hand and if South plays low insert the ♦9. Much of the time North will win with the ♦J or ♦10. If so you are no worse off, you play South for the ♦K. But if it happens that South was dealt both the ♦J and ♦10 then North will have to win that trick with the ♦K, or perhaps not even win it at all!

As you see, the Deep Finesse of the ♦9 pays off here, where the straightforward finesse of the ♦Q would lose the contract. Two chances are definitely better than one.

But what if South has played the ♦10, splitting his honors?

You would put on dummy's ♦Q and North would win the ♦K. But you aren't down yet! Later you lead another ♦ toward dummy's ♦ A 9 and finesse South for the ♦J.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

♠ K 7 6 2
♥ 5
♦ K J 8 7 4 3
♣ 7 2

♠ Q J 10 9 3
♥ K 7 6 4
♦ A
♣ J 10 3



♠ 5
♥ Q 10 9 8 2
♦ 9 2
♣ 9 8 6 5 4

♠ A 8 4
♥ A J 3
♦ Q 10 6 5
♣ A K Q

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3♦
Pass	4♦	Pass	5♦
All Pass			

5♦ by South
Lead: ♠Q

Partner's 3♣ bid is Stayman; with no 4-card Major you respond 3♦. Partner now bids 4♦.

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Partner wouldn't bypass 3NT unless he was pretty distributional. His bid is invitational and you have excellent ♦ help so you try 5♦.

South plays 5♦. West leads the ♠Q.

You may be wishing partner had said 3NT. But at 3NT West might have led a ♥, then you'd be wishing you were in 5♦.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2

This looks so easy let's check it by trying a winner count as well. Five ♦s (after ♦A is gone), the ♠ A K, the ♥A and the ♣ A K Q. Yes that adds up to 11 winners.

Is there ANY danger here at all?

Whenever a hand looks easy you should ask yourself what could go wrong. And here the only thing that could go wrong is if one of your ♠ winners gets ruffed. So how can you prevent that possibility?

If East has a singleton ♠, and West has the ♦A you might go down if you win the first trick in your hand. West will take his ♦A and play the ♠J. If you go up with dummy's ♠K East will ruff and you will still have a ♠ loser.

The simple solution is to win the first trick with dummy's ♠K. Now when West wins the ♦A and leads another ♠ it's a different situation. East may well ruff, but if he does you will just play a low card - East will have ruffed your ♠ **LOSER**.

You are a little unlucky that East has a singleton ♠.

But you are very lucky that you took the time to read this hand so you know how to play safely!

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ Q 7 ♥ K 10 9 2 ♦ 7 6 ♣ K Q J 8 2	
♠ A J 6 ♥ A Q 5 4 ♦ K Q 8 2 ♣ 7 3		♠ K 8 3 2 ♥ 7 6 3 ♦ A J 10 4 ♣ A 4
	♠ 10 9 5 4 ♥ J 8 ♦ 9 5 3 ♣ 10 9 6 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	2♣	Pass
2♥	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by West
Lead: ♣K

You have 12 points and a 4-card ♠ suit. To find a possible 4-4 fit you bid 2♣, the Stayman convention. Partner bids 2♥.

You have 12 points and a 4-card ♠ suit. To find a possible 4-4 fit you bid 2♣, the Stayman convention. Partner bids 2♥.

You were hoping for a ♠ response, but so be it. You now bid 3NT, knowing partner will correct to 4♠ if he was 4-4 in the Majors, or pass if he doesn't have 4 ♠s. He passes.

The contract would be 3NT played by East.

West plays 3NT.

North leads the ♣K, South follows with the ♣10. Do you hold up or not?

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 4 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 8

It makes no difference whether you hold up or not, (unless their ♣s are 7-2), so go ahead and take the first trick.

Either the ♥Q or the ♠J **MIGHT** become your ninth trick.

If you try either finesse and it wins you will make your contract. If you try either finesse and it loses you will be set immediately with ♣s. Each finesse is a 50% shot.

Is there anything you can do to improve your chances?

Of course - otherwise the question wouldn't have been asked! You can combine two chances. Obviously you cannot take both finesses, but you can try to drop the ♠Q in two pulls, and if she doesn't drop you still have the ♥ finesse to fall back on. So win the ♣A, play 4 ♦ winners and the ♠ A K, then see whether you have to try the ♥ finesse.

Aha - the ♠Q dropped so you take your 9 tricks.

But if she hadn't, you'd still have a 50% chance in ♥s.

Board 5
South Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ K 6 2 ♥ A Q ♦ 5 4 ♣ K Q J 9 7 2	
♠ J 10 8 4 ♥ K 7 5 3 ♦ J 10 9 3 ♣ 8	N W E S	♠ Q 9 5 ♥ 10 9 8 4 2 ♦ K 8 ♣ 10 5 4
	♠ A 7 3 ♥ J 6 ♦ A Q 7 6 2 ♣ A 6 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	4♣
Pass	6♣		
All Pass			

6♣ by North
Lead: ♥10

You are thinking slam; your first step is a jump to 3♣.

Partner says 4♣;

You are thinking slam; your first step is a jump to 3♣.

Partner says 4♣;

With partner agreeing ♣s, one possibility would be for you to cue-bid your ♥A. Another would be just to bid 6♣. You choose the second approach.

North plays 6♣. East leads the ♥10. West plays low and you win the ♥Q.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2

Your best chance at another winner is the ♦ suit. East MAY have both the ♦ K Q, if not you will have to establish the suit.

At trick 2 pull just one round of trumps with the ♣K. Then play a small ♦, finessing the ♦J when East plays low. West takes the ♦Q and returns the ♠J.

Go up with your ♠K, you may need the entry to dummy later. Pull one more trump with the ♣Q, then play a small ♦ to dummy's ♦A. Ruff a ♦ with a high trump, East discarding.

Enter dummy with the ♣A, pulling East's last trump as you do, and ruff one more ♦, establishing the fifth ♦. Enter dummy with the ♠A and discard your losing ♠ on the good ♦.

It is important to be careful with entries to the hand where you are trying to establish a suit.

If the suit splits evenly perhaps you can be a little sloppy and still get by.

But in cases like this one, with a 4-2 split, you cannot afford to waste an entry too early.

Board 6
East Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ K 7 4 3 ♥ Q 10 9 4 ♦ J 10 ♣ K 10 7	
♠ 6 ♥ A 7 5 3 2 ♦ 7 6 4 2 ♣ 8 5 4	N W E S	♠ A 10 5 2 ♥ 8 6 ♦ A K 3 ♣ A 9 6 2
	♠ Q J 9 8 ♥ K J ♦ Q 9 8 5 ♣ Q J 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♦	Pass	2♥	
All Pass			

2♥ by East
Lead: ♠Q

This situation comes up a lot. You don't have enough points to advance partner's 1NT opening, but you have a "long suit" that might play better than notrump. If "long suit" is 6 ♥s or 6 ♠s then pretty clearly you should transfer partner to that suit and then pass. But with only 5 of the Major it is tougher to say that 1NT would be an inferior contract. Here's a suggestion - with fewer than 9 points and a 5-card Major, transfer to that suit when you have a singleton or void, otherwise pass 1NT. So here you bid 2♦ and partner says 2♥.

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Of course you pass, that was the whole point of the transfer.

The contract would be 2♥ played by West.

East plays 2♥. South leads the ♠Q, North playing the ♠7.

We will all agree that you win the first trick with your ♠A.

Loser List: ♠ = 3 : ♥ = 2/3/? : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 :: Total = lots

In suit contracts it is usual to count losers. Sometimes in low level suit contracts it makes things clearer if you count winners. Here you have 4 high card winners in your hand plus the Ace of trumps in dummy.

Your plan will therefore be to make as many of dummy's small trumps as you can.

At trick 2 ruff a ♠ in dummy. Pull one trump with the ♥A. Play a ♣ back to your ♣A and ruff another ♠.

Got the idea? Play a ♦ to your ♦K and ruff your last ♠ in dummy. Then play the ♦A. If you've been counting you have taken the first 8 tricks. A good thing, too, because you aren't going to take any more.

In most suit contracts it is good to pull trumps early.

Here is an example of when that principle is **NOT** correct; when you need to get several ruffs with small trumps.